itself is a good example with a bleeding edge Fedora release every six months.

A company might withdraw support for a product or coerce you to upgrade a product that you have invested in, heavily, and are perfectly happy with in its current version. You will find no such compulsions with community-driven FOSS software. Communities do not vanish overnight—unlike software companies that sometimes do. And even if a community did vanish, in a worst-case scenario, with the source code available (remember, this is not closed source) you have your insurance papers right in the top drawer.

Hosting your own LMS is all very well. You also need to keep it current and supplied with content. This means you need to equip qualified lesson authors on your staff with the right tools. Most LMS have integrated authoring facilities. However, offline authoring and publishing has its attractions. It allows people to work in seclusion and then sync up with the LMS. A tool that enables offline authoring and publishing is eXe. It allows teachers and academics to focus on their content rather than the intricacies of HTML.

Most FOSS LMS have no-obligation demo sites. You can try these demos as often as you want and show them to the decision makers in your institution. Contrast this with the time-bound evaluation versions for proprietary software that give you the feeling that you are being done a favour.

I am sure you took your school timetable for granted. Either you remembered it all, at least the days you had two back-to-back history periods, or just didn't care and carried all the books you could. I bet you never realised then that timetabling is a constrained scheduling problem. Throw in a few thousand students, perhaps a hundred or more teachers with the usual set of courses, and timetabling becomes a really complicated business. Fortunately, there is FET (*www.lalescu.ro/liviu/fet*). It is a fairly capable tool with a certain learning curve and can scale very well from small schools to departments to large institutions. You can scan the fine-grain, enumerated feature list to check if it meets your requirements.

Learning by itself would be only half the fun were it not for the tests. Jokes apart, learning would not be complete without a reasonable and objective assessment. TCExam (*tcexam.com*) is a CBA/CBT (computer-based assessment/testing) system. It allows you to build a simple testing strategy. Built on the robust and familiar LAMP (Linux, Apache, MySQL, PHP/Python/Perl) stack, it supports rich content in the form of pretty-printed questions, formulae, and video/audio content. There are i18n (internationalisation) and accessibility features available for students with special needs, too. The application supports question banks so that each candidate gets her own unique test with a mix of questions. Such a feature is well suited for administering those on-demand tests that are very much in the news these days. The strong security and authentication features allow it to be used on the extranet as well.

Is it worth a try?

Unless you are already very happy with the information/learning management systems used in your school, the answer would be an emphatic, 'Yes'. That FOSS is a new technology and learning paradigm that should be taught to all students is an equally strong reason, in my opinion. Even if you do not want to jump on to the FOSS bandwagon with all your baggage, you can evaluate specific FOSS applications in isolation.

You could sandbox a portion of your computer lab network and run a small pilot with the active participation of teachers and students. There is nothing to lose; there are no evaluation licences or nagging salesmen spewing words like 'layered' and 'unbundled'. On the other hand, you might be amazed by how these solutions—individually or collaboratively—extend the reach of your teaching function and take the deployment of your learning course to the next level.

Not to make too fine a point of it, all FOSS applications have their source code available. This, along with the four freedoms of FOSS, allows you to customise and localise the software to your requirements and also contribute back to the community. Both of which, the eager, tech-savvy students of today would love doing. However, most, if not all the applications we have discussed so far seem to be usable out-of-the-box.

Do make sure, however, that you engage good technical help for the required handholding. And do not forget to familiarise yourself with the vocabulary used in the LMS domain. Is there a role for a 'Chief Education Officer' in institutions? Continuing education is the shape of things to come; perhaps it is not just coincidence that this role abbreviates to CEO! Fortunately, this role already exists in some organisations as Chief Learning Officer; so the real CEOs can breathe easy.

Once you start your journey, you might realise that it is not so much about technologies or paradigms as much as it is about prejudice, nay-sayers, entrenched mindsets, and commercial vested interests. Learning is all about discovery and breaking new ground. When are you starting on your voyage of discovery on what FOSS has to offer the world of education? END

References

- http://*www.rsmart.com/case/stanford-university-sakai-provides-significant-potential-and-opportunity*
- Screenshots are taken from *demolabo.com*, which runs demos of many packages and offers content under the cc-by-sa licence

By: Gurudutt Talgery

The author is an open source enthusiast and practitioner with over 20 years of industry experience working with reputed transnational companies. You can contact Gurudutt on gtalgery AT rediffmail DOT com